

Finance Thesis Course (BE451): Thesis Synopsis

The synopsis should broadly define two topics of interest for the thesis, 1 – 2 pages per topic. Each topic must contain (i) a tentative research question, (ii) potential data sources and empirical methods, and (iii) a short literature review with *at least three* references to papers close to the intended outcome and **published in a prominent journal in Finance**.¹ If you reference papers not published in a prominent journal (see footnote 1), your synopsis is unlikely to be accepted.

Based on students' synopses, the course director will allocate tutors to each group. You can suggest a tutor you would like to be assigned to, but there is no guarantee that this tutor will be allocated to you. A list of tutors and suggested topics is provided under "Resources". **Do not contact tutors yourself before you have been allocated to one**; you should work on the synopsis independently. Once you have been allocated a tutor, you can contact them to set up a meeting (but they are instructed to contact you about this).

A good synopsis shows that the students researched whether the project is **feasible** (access to datasets, complexity of the estimation methods, doable within the limited time-frame available) and pinned down the important papers closest to their project in the **literature**.

The synopsis should be submitted on Canvas under "Assignments" → "Synopsis submission" as a pdf. The **deadline** for submission is **September 9, 13.00**. File title: BScThesis_Surname1_Surname2.pdf. The head of the synopsis document should contain the name of the students and preferred tutor (if any). *Please respect these simple instructions carefully!*

Students that did not find a partner to write the thesis before the synopsis deadline will be assigned a partner or, in exceptional circumstances, may work alone. It is preferred that students find a partner to work with on their own.

Once the tutor for each group is assigned, they will send an email to each student to schedule the first individual meeting at most two weeks after the deadline. The goal of this initial meeting is to choose the best topic written in the synopsis, define the research question in line with the existing literature, establish the methodology, and start the thesis on a solid basis.

The list of suggested topics by each tutor is intended to provide students with an initial direction for designing a research question and familiarize the students with the research interests of each tutor. If you decide to write a thesis on one of these subjects, it is still necessary to carefully develop the research question and evaluate the feasibility of the project in the synopsis. These topics are under no circumstances a guarantee of a successful thesis. Also,

¹ The Journal of Finance, Journal of Financial Economics, The Review of Financial Studies, The Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis, The Review of Finance, The Quarterly Journal of Economics, American Economic Review, Journal of Economic Literature, Journal of Political Economy, Econometrica, Review of Economic Studies, Journal of Monetary Economics, Journal of Economic Theory, Journal of Econometrics, The Review of Economics and Statistics.

several students may want to work on the same topic, and in the end of course only one group can.

At most 1 of the 2 topics of the synopsis can be inspired from the topics suggested by the tutors.

An excellent starting point of a thesis is to (partially) replicate an interesting paper published recently in a top journal and attempt to make an extension. Thus, the synopsis would establish that the students have access to the relevant datasets and methodology and suggest an extension.

If the synopsis has its main references from other journals than from the list of top journals provided or if you did not properly investigate whether you have access to the databases that you plan to use, this can affect your final grade. Your synopsis needs to include proper references and a bibliography (check the syllabus on how to make references and the bibliography) for each topic.

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